thames view

ISSUE 2

YOUR COMMUNITY MAGAZINE

MARCH 05

Target Thamesmead

Launched by Bexley Council, the Community Safety Action Zone (CSAZ) works in partnership with a number of agencies and volunteer groups. Drawing together the skills of these specialist groups, CSAZ takes a highly targeted approach to tackling crime and anti social behaviour. All CSAZ partners bring a different perspective to the question of safety in the neighbourhood. At fortnightly operational meetings, the group shares news and information using their combined experience to help find ways to reduce crime levels. Their goal has just been given a boost with the arrival of a dedicated Safer Neighbourhoods Police Team. Based at the Bexley Business Academy in Yarnton Way, the 8-strong team are ideally placed to become a real part of the local Thamesmead community. Sgt. Mark Eley says: "The team is looking forward to working in Thamesmead. We will we working hard to make contact with the residents and make ourselves as accessible as possible."

Under the Safer Neighbourhoods initiative the police team will not be used for other policing activities outside the borough. With the focus firmly on Thamemead, Sgt. Eley's team hopes to build up their local knowledge and understanding of the community. Against this background they can identify the real issues that residents face and can find workable ways to resolve them. Sgt. Eley plans "to build a strong working relationship with people living here and wants residents to feel confident to approach us for a chat, or come to us with any concerns they may have."

You can help

CSAZ is made up of representatives from Gallions, Neighbourhood Watch, Bexley Council, Team Gallions, Bexley Community Safety Partnership and Youth Services. This wide cross-section has the experience to make a real difference to your neighbourhood. However, what would really help is your input – as a Thamesmead resident you know better than anyone where the problems lie and what realistic steps can be taken to solve them.

If you are interested in joining the CSAZ Residents' Panel please contact Martin Hogan on 0208 320 3462.



TAVY BRIDGE TIMELINE
Keeping up to date with the latest news

WARDENS WATCH
Meeting the people the wardens meet

ONE TO ONE
Making a difference to Thamesmead

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

Tavy Bridge Timeline

The regeneration of Tavy Bridge will go on long after the bulldozers and diggers have left the area. As well as bright new homes, we want to help build a thriving, diverse community where families old and young alike can live, work and socialise together.

To oversee this side of Tavy Bridge's development, Gallions has appointed Linda Nash as Regeneration Project Officer for Community and Economic Development. Linda will be working closely with you to help make Tavy Bridge an enjoyable and safe place to live. She says:" I want to identify the needs and hopes of the local community. With their help and support I will introduce projects and opportunities which will address all aspects of community life."

Linda's work will focus on a number of key areas such as education, training, health and employment. Working with external agencies, she wants to ensure that everyone living in the Tavy Bridge area has access to vocational training. For Linda however, training is just a starting point.
Her plans include investigating opportunities for local labour schemes while aiming to secure apprenticeships in all elements of construction. In short, Linda wants to develop a community that has the skills and the abilities to access the employment market.

It's not all about work and Linda's plans include ideas to develop social and recreational activities that all the community can enjoy. Additionally, she will work with established service providers to ensure the Tavy Bridge community has access to a wide range of health services. For those who like to keep in shape, Linda is hoping to work with local fitness centres to provide affordable access to exercise. Linda knows that there are many challenges ahead.

"There is a long way to go and a lot of work to be done in maximising the opportunities for Tavy Bridge. However, we are determined to turn Tavy Bridge into an area to be proud of and, with help from the residents, we can achieve this goal and much more."

If you have ideas on what services you would like to see provided or just for more information on how you can get involved contact Linda Nash on 020 8320 3451. Mobile: 07867 526599 or by email lnash@gallionsha.co.uk



ISSUE #2

editorial

Talk of the Town

At Gallions we are always looking for ways to provide you with an outstanding service. In this issue of Thamesview you will read about the changes we have made to our customer services team - a new name and new opening hours are just some of the ways we are streamlining our service. We will also be introducing you to our website www.gallionsha.co.uk. It has been designed with your needs in mind and we hope you will find it helpful, informative and most of all interesting. So, whether you want to talk to us via the web or would prefer a face-to-face chat we have the tools and even more time for both.

Thamesview is your magazine and it is important to us that we know your point of view. If you have something to say that other residents need to hear why not give the team at Thamesview a call on 0208 320 3414.

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Making your community safer

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Building a neighbourhood for all

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Working towards Decent Homes 2010

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Sue Chalkley talks development

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A quick round up of the latest news

Maintaining Standards

At Gallions we are committed to meeting the Decent Homes deadline of 2010. The first phase of our planned investment programme targets 509 properties and looks at replacing windows, renewing roof coverings and upgrading kitchens, bathrooms and wiring. We caught up with one resident whose home has already enjoyed a makeover, and she couldn't be happier.



Mrs Cullen was more than happy with a little inconvenience for the sake of a brand new kitchen.

Mrs Carmel Cullen has lived in Thamesmead for 30 years. With four children, thirteen grandchildren and a first great grandchild on the way, she has spent a lot of her time in the kitchen. She was delighted to hear that her home would be one of the first to be refurbished. After choosing the units and flooring she wanted, Mrs Cullen's flat in Trewsbury House was given a brand new kitchen and completely rewired in less than 4 weeks – a timescale Gallions is hoping to reduce. While Gallions cannot insist that residents take up the offer of a new kitchen or bathroom, the association does have a statutory requirement to ensure that the wiring meets current legal standards. As the majority of the properties in Thamesmead are constructed in concrete it is not possible to chase the wiring into the walls. However, the electricians have found a very neat, surface-mounted solution to overcome this problem.

Mrs Cullen's home is part of a scheme that will be rolled out across Thamesmead over the next six years. Terry Bird, Gallions' Head of Asset Management, understands that resident involvement is essential and is currently experimenting with the idea of introducing a contractor's on site Resident Liaison Officer. This would help provide a smooth refurbishment programme while ensuring any problems are resolved quickly. He is also planning to introduce a survey-based assessment procedure to help identify complete decent home packages for all properties. The team is confident that service delivery will improve as the plans roll out and contractors get used to streamlining processes. Terry says:

"We want to keep the disruption to an absolute minimum and we need the co-operation of both residents and contractors to complete the works timely. That's why we put contractors' site accommodation adjacent to where they are working – ease of access and easily available to talk to residents. What's more, the contractors are aware that they must restore both the water and electricity supplies to each home at the end of the working day."

Terry is keen to stress that Gallions provides an on-going maintenance service where all properties are reviewed over time to ensure they remain firmly within the Decent Homes framework.



Take a walk with the Wardens



Sue Kennedy campaigned for the wardens

As a resident and member of Coldharbour and Avery Hill's Neighbourhood renewal scheme, Sue Kennedy is delighted with the latest arrival in her area – neighbourhood wardens. She has seen for herself how the young and old alike in Thamesmead have benefited from the many community projects the wardens have introduced.

Sue says: "There's not a lot for the kids to do around here and it's important that there are some diversionary activities on offer." She is confident that when the residents see the positive contribution the wardens will make to the community that they will enjoy high levels of support. "People need to see for themselves real results and then they will begin to understand how the wardens can help meet the needs of the whole community."

The neighbourhood wardens' scheme in Sue's area is supported and funded by Greenwich Council. This is the first time Gallions wardens have 'outsourced' their services and they are looking forward to bringing some of their award-winning initiatives to Greenwich.

New Faces in Bexley

In Thamesmead the neighbourhood warden scheme has expanded to the Bexley side, with four wardens now operating two shifts. Their patrols include visits to Sanderling Court and Teeswater Atrium. Whether the wardens are playing darts with the elderly residents or checking that the windows are secured at night, all agree that they are a very welcome sight.

Team Gallions



In January 2005, the police removed 22 untaxed cars from Thamesmead's roads. Operation CUBIT gives police the powers to lift and remove any untaxed cars or any vehicles deemed to be a danger to the public. What's more, they don't have to give any notice to the owners that their car is about to be towed away. It's always an expensive business getting your car back and could even cost you more than getting it taxed. Parking on Gallions' land with a SORN notice won't save you – they must be on a private drive or in a garage. So remember, if you don't want to lose your car to CUBIT, don't forget to tax it.

Clearing up the canal

During the winter lull, Team Gallions' landscape team are having another big drive on keeping the canal clear. We are delighted to have the help of Thames 21, a government-aided organisation. We would also like to thank those residents who have offered to help in our clear up operation. Current Health and Safety considerations however have made it very difficult for us to take you up on it, but we're working on it! If you are interested in taking part on a voluntary basis please contact Irene George on 0208 320 3445.

Rubbish Removal

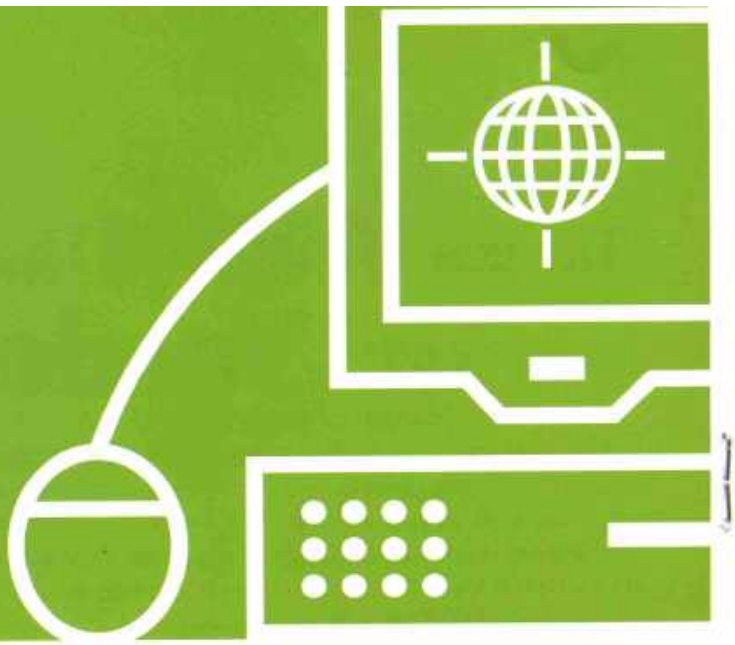
As from April we will collect rubbish only from those householders who have phoned in advance to arrange collection. So if you live in Southmere, Lesnes, or Parkview, and want us to take away your rubbish on Saturday April 2nd, or Monday April 4th, phone 0800 83 84 81, and we can arrange a convenient time to be on the street outside your home.

But remember –
YOU load the rubbish,
WE take it away.

RUBBISH COLLECTION
SATURDAY APRIL 2ND
OR MONDAY 4TH APRIL
PHONE 0800 83 84 81

Gallions Freephone 0800 83 84 81

let the Web do the work

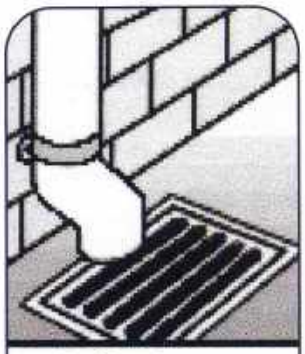


Gallions has now unveiled its new and improved website with many great online facilities. www.gallionsha.co.uk includes a dedicated residents section that has been designed to offer you as much help and information as possible. Whether you have a query about repairs or want to pay your rent on-line, all you need to know is simply a click away.

Here is a quick guide to some of the services you will find in the residents section.

Paying your rent

billsonline.com is a special website run by the Post Office. It provides a safe and secure way for you to pay your rent on line. It is quick and easy to register but do make sure you have your rent details to hand before you set up your account. Also, you will be asked to enter a user name and a password, so it is worth having a think about that too. Billsonline.com allows you to pay rent by either debit or credit card – you cannot however, pay your rent with Direct Debit through billsonline.com. The system will store your details and your rent payment will be deducted automatically. Paying your rent electronically couldn't be easier and it means there is one less thing to think about if you are short of time. For more details about paying your rent online please go to the residents section and select revenue. There you will find a step-by-step guide to setting up your rent account. What are you waiting for?

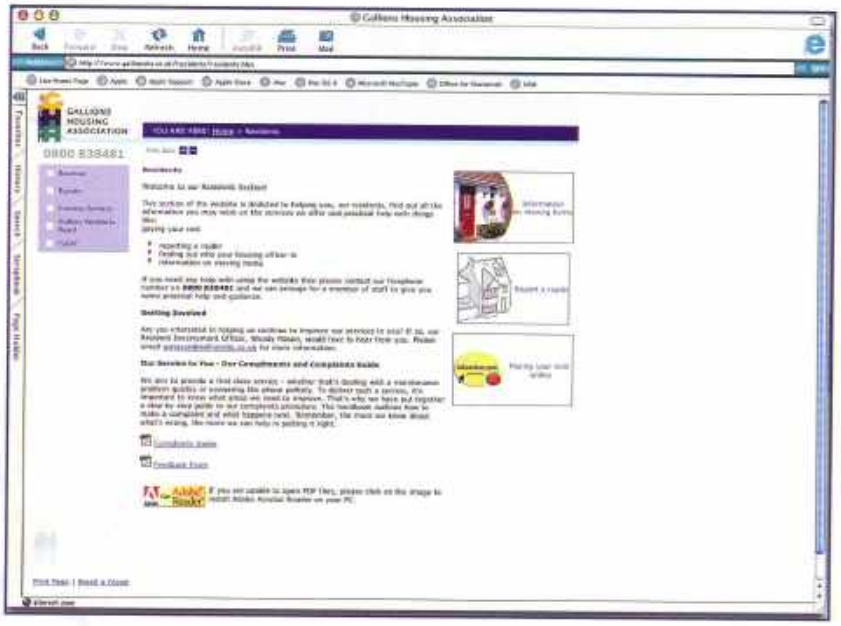


Online Images

Reporting a repair

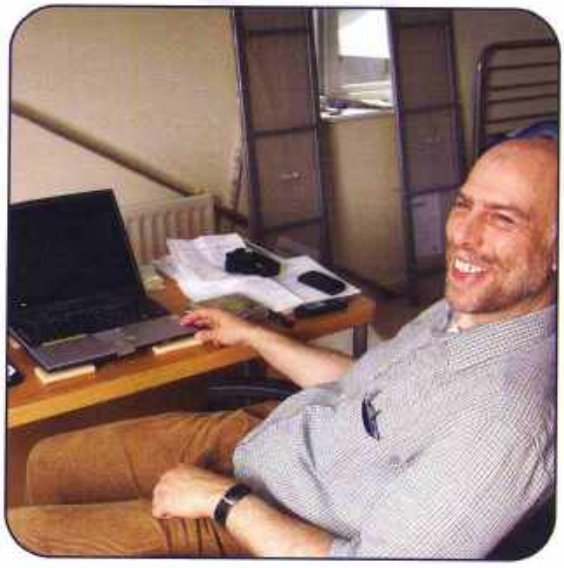
We want to respond to your repair needs as quickly as possible. But sometimes it is not always easy to explain exactly what the problem is. Our online repair reporting service has been designed to make the whole process as simple as possible. Using pictures and graphics you can highlight what room or area the fault is in. From there you will be offered a series of options that will help pinpoint the exact problem. The precision of this system ensures that we get the right information straight away and you get an engineer as soon as possible. You will find details of our repair service by going to the residents section and selecting report a repair. You can then select request a repair online and will be connected to our automated repair service.

Housing Services



Whether you are a tenant, leaseholder, freeholder or simply applying for a home, this section is full of important information. It provides a complete package for leaseholders with details of how to sell their homes and outlining their repair responsibilities. Also included is a comprehensive question and answer section for the most frequently asked leaseholder questions. For tenants there are details of how to move home and for those hoping to apply for a home you can read about the choice based lettings scheme run by Greenwich council. Within this section you will also be able to download the tenants handbook. However, if you would like to talk to your housing co-ordinator simply click on the appropriate button to access a list detailing who is responsible for your area. Direct telephone numbers and email address will allow you to get in touch with your housing co-ordinator quickly.

The residents section also includes the latest updates from two core residents groups -Gallions Residents Board (GRB) and the Equality and Diversity Panel (EaDiP). Other options on the www.gallionsha.co.uk home page include projects and home ownership. Under projects you will find the latest news and views from Tavy Bridge as well as details of what development plans Gallions has in the pipeline.



Our website is your opportunity to keep up to date with what's happening at Gallions. It is updated regularly with news and features and is an ideal way to make sure you don't miss out on important information.

Coming soon to a screen near you

UK online is a company committed to making computers accessible to as many people as possible. Their name can be seen in community centres, libraries, village halls - in fact, just about anywhere. UK online is now bringing its travelling roadshow to Thamesmead. They will be arriving next month in a bus packed with computers and are on hand to teach basic computer skills or simply let you use their computer should you need to. More details about UK online's services can be found in next months Thamesview.

You talked, we listened

Firstly, a huge ' thank you' to all those residents who took the time to complete our questionnaire. The excellent response rate has meant that we can get a really clear idea of what you think of the services we offer and how we can improve on them. While we were pleased to learn that over 75% of residents are very happy with what we provide, we also know that there is room for continued improvement.

Environment

Although we have made a number of key improvements, residents were in general still concerned about minor crime, vandalism, litter and graffiti within their neighbourhood. That's why we have increased the number of Neighbourhood Wardens around Thamesmead. Also Team Gallions, working with a number of local residents, have identified 'key target' areas and are finding ways to reduce graffiti in these particular spots. We are always looking at ways to reduce crime and are delighted with the arrival of a dedicated police team for the Thamesmead community.



Mrs Kattenhorn was one of the lucky winners of our prize draw. "There is more sweeping and cleaning, things have improved."

Housing & Property Services

Housing Co-ordinators play an important role within our organisation and we want to ensure that they provide you with a first class service. All our Housing Co-ordinators will under go Customer Services training to ensure that their communication skills are up to scratch. For many of you the Housing Co-ordinator is your first port of call in a crisis - individual action plans have been agreed with housing co-ordinators allowing Gallions to establish high standards across the board.

While generally residents were very happy with the repairs service we offer we are not resting on our laurels and are continuing to find ways to improve standards through our partnership with Axis Europe. We know that some of you have found it difficult to contact the right person at Gallions. Things should be much easier now, as we have made some changes to our customer facing teams. Instead of two teams we now have a central customer contact team who are all trained to deal with any enquiry. This will limit the need for transferring calls and waiting for the right person to get to your query. Turn to the back page of Thamesview for more details.

Information & Involvement

While the rent statement was found to be useful it was also felt that some parts of it were difficult to understand. We want to present important information as clearly as possible. The revenue team is currently looking at the design and content of each rent statement and we will shortly be putting plans in place to ensure that your rent statements are easier to understand. What's more you will see that your comments about the residents' newsletter have been taken on board. This is the second issue of the new-look newsletter and we hope it provides you with more information about what's going on in your neighbourhood.

And finally, for those of you who wanted to get involved with the residents board the good news is there's nothing stopping you! We have a great Resident Involvement Team who are just waiting for your call on 0800 83 84 81. Or you can send an email to getinvolved@gallionsha.co.uk

one to one

Developing Communities

Sue Chalkley, has seen many changes in the provision and management of social housing over the last twenty years. Today, she is using that experience to help shape the future of Gallions Housing Association.

While the world of housing is changing, one thing that remains constant is the absolute need to provide residents with a streamlined service. Sadly, this basic principle is often overlooked. Not so with Sue Chalkley. As Gallions Development and Regeneration Director, Sue is responsible for many areas of corporate growth – regeneration projects, stock transfer, shared ownership schemes. Despite the high profile nature of her work, Sue's all-round experience of the housing sector ensures that she never loses sight of the key issues.

"At Gallions we aim to be more than a social landlord. Being responsible for properties in one location allows us to really get behind community initiatives. We are fully committed at a corporate level and work closely with residents to meet their needs and incorporate their ideas."

At a Board meeting in October 2004 it was agreed that in order to compete successfully in the increasingly competitive housing sector, Gallions needed to extend its horizons. That decision has lead to the association targeting a number of key housing projects beyond Thamesmead. Sue believes that the unique experience we have had in Thamesmead will help Gallions expand and embrace new challenges along the way. The first of these challenges is to win the tender for the regeneration of the Kidbrooke estate in Greenwich. Sue and her team are working hard with consortium partners to submit the tender in early March.

"To win a tender such as Kidbrooke it is important to show how innovative your plans are. New ideas, intelligent designs and a keen environmental approach all help. However, another key area is how closely the tenants will be involved. At Tavy Bridge we have consulted with and informed our residents at every stage. With such an enormous project clear communication is essential."

With more development staff coming on board, it is clear that Gallions is committed to long-term progress – progress which Sue firmly believes will benefit the residents of Thamesmead. One of the company's key objectives is to invest in creating sustainable neighbourhoods in the Thames Gateway and using Thamesmead as a showcase for what they can achieve. Gallions' growth allows the association to demonstrate the benefits of life in Thamesmead to a much wider audience. Promoting Thamesmead as an attractive and affordable place to live will encourage new businesses, key workers, families and professionals to the area. Sue firmly believes that the pipeline development plans will help kick-start the process of changing people's perception of Thamesmead.



Dates for your diary

Neighbourhood Forums - An opportunity to have your say on local community issues and to put your point to Gallions' representatives.

Broadwaters

Monday 7th March, 6.30pm Village Hall

Wendy Mason
Tel: 0208 320 3417

Southmere

Tuesday 22nd March, 7.00pm Tavy Bridge Hall

Crossway

Tuesday 19th April, 6.30pm Manor Close Community Hall

Lesnes, Parkview and Greenmead

Monday 25th April, 6.30 pm Atrium (Teeswater Court)

Thamesmead East Community Safety Action Zone Residents Panel

Next meeting will be held on 7th April. Come along and hear what steps are being taken to reduce levels of crime and disorder in the area. **For more information please contact Martin Hogan on 0208 320 3462 or Annette Hines of the Bexley community safety partnership on 0208 284 5507**

LEASEHOLDERS LINE

Remember, morning surgery drop in sessions are held on the first Thursday of every month 10am till 12pm. All other times need an appointment.

ASB HOTLINE

The anti social behaviour hotline gives you the opportunity to report disruptive or nuisance behaviour. It is an automated system and you will reach a recorded message asking for details of the problem. The hotline is monitored and your message will be forwarded to the appropriate authorities. Please note that our hotline is simply there to record the details of your complaint - it is not a responsive service and should not be used in an emergency situation. We want to stamp out anti-social behaviour and we need your help to do it.



News Review



Changes and Choices

The deadline for the changes to benefit payments system is drawing nearer. If you need help in setting up a bank account or simply want some advice about how the changes might affect you, **please contact Lesley Edwards on 0208 320 3495**. Lesley runs regular drop in meetings at the Tavy Bridge project office.
She's there to help you make the right choices.

getinvolved@gallionsha.co.uk

The Resident Involvement Team is here to help make your community projects and initiatives a reality.
By working closely together we hope to meet the neighbourhood's needs and to provide support and advice where possible. We need you to tell us what you want. The team has now got its own dedicated email address and is waiting to hear from you.

Take a walk with us

We know that many of you are very interested in the up-keep of your community and the local environment. That's why we have established our Estate Walkabouts for residents. These inspections are carried out every 3 months and focus on areas such as cleanliness, graffiti, door security systems, landscaping and play equipment facilities. The inspection team is made up of a representative from Team Gallions, the GRB, our building services team and the appropriate housing co-ordinator.

If you would like more information on how you can participate in community projects or contribute your ideas please contact either Wendy Mason or Martin Hogan on: 0800 83 84 81 or e-mail **getinvolved@gallionsha.co.uk**

PRINCE'S TRUST TEAM: THAMESMEAD 25

The Prince's Trust, through Bexley Education Business Partnership, is running a new round of personal development team challenges in Thamesmead. The first 12-week programme started at the end of February and Thames View will be following the team's progress over the coming months.

The personal development programme is a great opportunity for young people to tackle new challenges, develop new interests and generally expand their horizons.

With activities ranging from climbing and canoeing to two-week community projects, the programme is an ideal way to encourage strong team building and working skills. Dressed in distinctive black and red T-shirts the team will soon be spending 2 weeks with local organisations and residents.

They will be given tasks that will help improve the environment and life for the neighbourhood. Why not keep your eye out for the team and offer a few words of encouragement if you



see them around? The next Princes Trust Programme will start in the summer and is open to local people between the ages of 16 and 25 who are not in work or education. If you are interested in joining a future team or would simply like more information about this initiative, **please contact Katie Collins, Ricky Philips or Elizabeth Allen on 0208 303 7777 extension 4236**

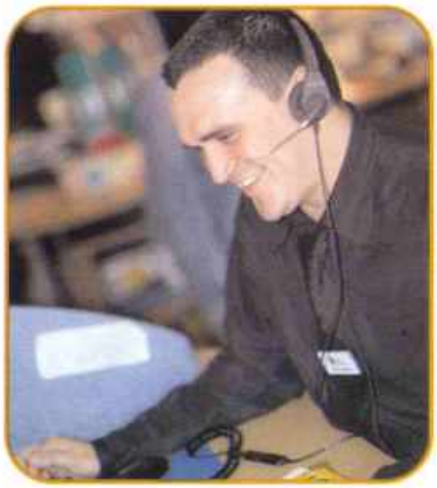


GALLIONS FREEPHONE 0800 83 84 81

Open all Hours

There have been some changes within our customer services department which we hope will be of help to you. We have decided to streamline our two customer care centres (response and service) by bringing them under one banner called the Customer Contact Team. Working together has given us more scope to meet your needs particularly in times of peak periods. We know that it is not always easy to find the time to come in and see us, especially if you are working all day.

As a result, we have extended our reception opening hours and you can now call at our office from 8am every weekday. For those that have early starts in the morning, we also now offer a late opening night on Wednesday with reception and the telephones open until 8pm. And if you can't get to us at all during the week we have also introduced a Saturday morning service, with reception and telephones open from 10am to 1pm. We hope these new, flexible opening hours will help make it easier for you to get in touch with us.



Mon Tues Thurs Fri – 8am – 5pm
Wed 8am – 8pm
Sat 10am – 1pm

ਜੇ ਅੰਗਰੇਜ਼ੀ ਤੁਹਾਡੀ ਪਹਿਲੀ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਨਹੀਂ, ਅਤੇ ਤੁਸੀਂ ਇਸ ਦਸਤਾਵੇਜ਼ ਦਾ ਤਰਜਮਾ ਚਾਹੁੰਦੇ ਹੋ, ਤਾਂ ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ ਆਪਣੀ ਚੁਣੀ ਹੋਈ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਦੇ ਨਾਂ ਦੇ ਨੇੜੇ ਵਾਲੇ ਖ਼ਾਨੇ ਵਿਚ ਸਹੀ ਦਾ ਨਿਸ਼ਾਨ ਲਾ ਕੇ, ਅਤੇ ਦੱਸੀ ਹੋਈ ਥਾਂ 'ਤੇ ਆਪਣਾ ਨਾਂ ਅਤੇ ਪਤਾ ਲਿਖ ਕੇ ਇਹ ਫ਼ਾਰਮ ਕਿਸੇ ਲਿਫ਼ਾਫ਼ੇ ਵਿਚ ਪਾ ਕੇ ਹੇਠ ਲਿਖੇ ਪਤੇ 'ਤੇ ਭੇਜ ਦਿਓ।

如果英語不是您的母語，您希望將該文件翻譯出來的話，請在您選擇的語言旁邊打勾，請在所示之處填上您的姓名和地址，併用信封將本表格寄到下列地址。

Nếu Anh ngữ không phải là ngôn ngữ chính, Quý vị muốn dịch tài liệu này, xin vui lòng đánh dấu vào ô kế bên ngôn ngữ Quý vị chọn, ghi tên và địa chỉ vào nơi chỉ dẫn và gởi mẫu vào phòng bì theo địa chỉ dưới đây.

PUNJABI ☐ **CHINESE** ☐ **VIETNAMESE** ☐

(please tick one)

Name: _____

Address: _____

_____

_____

Return to: Joy McKee, Translation Requests, Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH

Contact us

Gallions Housing Association
Harrow Manor Way
London
SE2 9XH

For all enquiries please contact the
Customer Response Centre
0800 83 84 81
It's a freephone number that you can use to book services, repairs or for any other enquiries.

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION